Papers 3 and 4 — practice papers and answer guide

Cambridge Islamic Studies 9488 • October/November 2026 preparation • 29 October 2026

Independent author-written practice. NOT a Cambridge paper, NOT leaked content and NOT a guarantee of November topics. Question selection is informed by the linked audit and the current syllabus. Marking guidance is indicative, not an official Cambridge mark scheme. Worked responses illustrate technique; no fixed mark or grade is promised.

1. Paper 3 — practice examination

Heritage of Islam • 1 hour 30 minutes • 50 marks

Answer **one** question from Section A and **one** from Section B. Each question totals 25 marks: (a) 10 and (b) 15. In Section A(a), use the supplied source and your own knowledge. The text sources below are original teaching descriptions, not quotations from a medieval author or substitutes for practising genuine exam images.

Section A — answer Question 1 OR Question 2

Source A: an author-written description of a mosque

A mosque occupies a site used for worship before Islam. Its courtyard opens into a large prayer hall. Reused columns and mosaic landscapes appear alongside arrangements for congregational Muslim worship. A tower makes the building visible across the city.

1(a) Explain how Umayyad architecture expressed Islamic belief while adapting earlier traditions. Refer to Source A and your own knowledge. **[10]**

1(b) “Religious policies were more important than political and economic policies to the success of the Umayyads.” Evaluate this statement. **[15]**

Source B: an author-written account of intellectual enquiry

A scholar studies an earlier account of vision. Rather than accepting the authority of its author, he compares the account with the behaviour of light passing through a small opening into a dark space. He records observations and uses mathematical reasoning to examine his explanation.

2(a) Explain how observation and reasoning contributed to scientific achievements in the Islamic world during the Abbasid era. Refer to Source B and one scientist you have studied. **[10]**

2(b) “Openness to other traditions was the main reason for the success of Abbasid learning.” Discuss. **[15]**

Section B — answer Question 3 OR Question 4

3(a) Explain how two significant works by Muslims use different approaches to understanding Islamic beliefs. **[10]**

3(b) “Reasoning about the natural world is sufficient for explaining Islamic beliefs to people today.” Evaluate this statement. **[15]**

4(a) Explain how features of two mosques you have studied communicate Islamic beliefs. **[10]**

4(b) “Preserving traditional architecture is more important than creating new styles.” Discuss with reference to Muslim beliefs and communities. **[15]**

2. Paper 4 — practice examination

Islam in the modern world • 1 hour 30 minutes • 50 marks

Answer **two** questions. Each essay is worth **25 marks**, assessed as knowledge/understanding 10 and analysis/evaluation 15. Do not divide your answer into artificial (a)/(b) sections.

1 “Muslim women can exercise public leadership without compromising their religious values.” Evaluate this statement with reference to a recent

Muslim woman and women from the past whom you have studied. **[25]**

2 “Cooperation with other faiths is the best response to the challenges faced by Muslim minorities.” Discuss with reference to two contemporary countries or communities you have studied. **[25]**

3 “The duty to obey Muslim leaders is less important than the duty to hold them accountable.” Discuss with reference to Islamic teachings and examples of leadership. **[25]**

3. How to use the answer guidance

Attempt the paper BEFORE reading the plans. Mark knowledge and evaluation separately. The official June 2026 P3 and P4 descriptors are the reference point:

- **AO1, 9–10:** detailed, accurate and relevant knowledge with developed understanding, addressing the question fully.
- **AO1, 6–8:** mostly accurate relevant knowledge with a developed response covering most aspects.
- **AO1, 3–5 / 1–2:** increasingly partial or limited knowledge/understanding; 0 for no relevant material.
- **AO2, 13–15:** analyse the strength/importance of different views in detail; accurate evidence; coherent argument and conclusion assessing alternatives.
- **AO2, 10–12:** discuss views in some detail with evidence and a coherent evaluative conclusion.
- **AO2, 7–9:** recognise alternatives, develop at least one, and reach a clear linked conclusion.
- **AO2, 4–6 / 1–3:** increasingly basic supported view or largely unsupported assertion; 0 for no relevant material.

These are abbreviated descriptors, not a checklist giving one automatic mark per fact. Use best-fit judgement and ask a teacher to calibrate marking. Do not award a high AO2 band merely because “however” appears in each paragraph.

4. Paper 3 indicative plans — all questions

Q1(a): belief, adaptation and the source

A developed answer could select three or four connected points:

- Source's reused columns / earlier sacred site -> continuity of material and skilled techniques; Damascus under al-Walid I supplies a named example.
- Prayer hall / congregation -> worship, common qiblah and communal unity; the function changed even where materials survived.
- Mosaic landscapes -> beautification and possible reflection on abundance/Paradise; distinguish interpretation from certainty.
- Tower -> public call/visibility of faith; no claim that all surviving parts date unchanged to the Umayyads.
- Calligraphy and rejection of images of God, if introduced from own knowledge, should be clearly distinguished from what the source explicitly says.

To improve: integrate the source throughout rather than append “as seen in the source”. A catalogue of domes and arches without religious meaning is incomplete. The source does not mention a dome: do not invent one as a visible feature.

Q1(b): relative importance of policies

Define success: religious influence, stable governance, welfare or lasting legacy. Set the criterion early.

Religious case: mosques enabled prayer/teaching and public Islamic identity; Damascus provides a concrete example. Religion could legitimise the community and spread its practices.

Alternative: Abd al-Malik's administration and coinage, communications and economic activity made the state governable and supported religious provision. Military/political consolidation may explain survival better than construction alone.

Weigh: a mosque can be both a religious and political project. Institutions supporting faith depend on resources; economic stability is a means, not necessarily the ultimate Islamic purpose.

Conclusion: explain which policy was most important under the criterion chosen and why the strongest rival does not overturn it. Avoid claiming every Umayyad caliph had an identical motive.

Q2(a): method through a scientist

Use Source B's questioning of authority, restricted light path, recording and mathematical analysis. Connect these with Ibn al-Haytham's Book of Optics and light entering rather than emanating from the eye. Explain what made evidence relevant to the claim. Mention his Fatimid Egyptian context to avoid making him a Baghdad court employee.

If using an alternative scientist, explicitly connect that scientist's work to the methods in the source rather than misidentifying the source's unnamed scholar. A general biography without method would not fully answer the question.

Q2(b): openness and other causes

For: Greek/Syriac, Persian and Indian learning enlarged the available knowledge; multi-faith translators such as Hunayn ibn Ishaq show a mechanism of exchange.

Against “main”: patronage, book culture, commercial networks, practical demand and independent criticism were also necessary. Merely possessing translations cannot explain improvements in optics or medicine.

Limits: openness varied; theological coercion such as the mihna complicates an image of unlimited tolerance. Avoid presenting one Baghdad institution as every scholar's workplace.

Judgement: explain whether openness was foundational, sufficient, or one enabling condition among others. Show how factors interacted.

Q3(a): two actual works

Hayy ibn Yaqzan: narrative of an isolated learner; observation/reason leading to metaphysical and spiritual reflection; later encounter with community and communication problems.

Incoherence: critical reasoning about twenty philosophical positions; limits of claims to demonstration in metaphysics; relation to revealed beliefs. Use a specific issue such as causation, creation or resurrection.

Compare: different emphasis, not “Ibn Tufayl reason / Ghazali no reason”. Both use intellectual enquiry. Another permitted pair may be used if treated with equivalent specificity.

Q3(b): whether natural reasoning is sufficient

For: shared experience, accessibility across faith commitments, Qur'an 3:190–191; Hayy's narrative as a concrete example. Can reach questions about order, dependency and a Creator.

Limits: observation does not independently specify prayer obligations, every attribute of God or all teachings about the unseen. People interpret evidence differently; moral and intellectual preparation varies.

Other methods: revelation, careful textual explanation, spiritual reflection, personal example and dialogue. Qur'an 16:125 favours wisdom rather than one rigid method.

Judgement: distinguish a starting point from sufficient explanation of the religion as a whole. Tailor the conclusion to audience and purpose.

Q4(a): two mosque examples

For Sultan Ahmed: domed communal space, calligraphy and minarets -> awe, worship, unity, remembrance. For Djenné: local earthen form, prayer orientation and collective maintenance -> shared worship and stewardship. Explain function and religious interpretation, not just “blue tiles look nice”.

Use at least one precise feature from EACH mosque; show a shared belief with a difference in expression. No need to force every feature to mean a

theological proposition: acknowledge practical construction and climate too.

Q4(b): preservation versus innovation

Preserve: continuity, historical knowledge, craftsmanship, identity and living worship; Djenné's renewal shows communal responsibility.

Innovate: accessibility, energy use, growing populations, local resources and contemporary needs; Islam has historically adapted forms.

Counterweights: heritage cost versus social welfare; new spectacle versus useful worship space. Preservation can include responsible change, while innovation can respect tradition.

Conclusion: specify standards—religious appropriateness, safety, community need and stewardship. Explain when one priority overrides the other; don't finish merely “both are important”.

5. Paper 4 indicative plans — all questions

Essay 1: women, public leadership and values

AO1 evidence: Qur'an 9:71 and 33:35; justice/trust criteria; Bhutto's two terms; Razia's sovereign role; Noor Jahan's court authority; Aisha's scholarship and Khadija's business as relevant early evidence. Use Bukhari 7099 only with accurate explanation of interpretive debate.

Argument supporting the statement: public responsibility can enact service and justice; gender does not itself establish inability or religious compromise. Different office types matter.

Alternative: some jurists restrict supreme political leadership; public office also creates real conflicts between party demands, integrity and religious commitments. Historical success does not by itself settle legal interpretation.

Evaluation: distinguish eligibility, personal religious identity and actual performance. Bhutto faced institutional constraints and governance controversies; she should not be idealised or dismissed solely because of

gender.

Conclusion: state what “without compromising” requires, identify conditions and assess the strongest restrictive view. A narrative biography alone cannot supply the necessary AO2.

Essay 2: cooperation and Muslim minorities

AO1 evidence: Qur'an 60:8, 5:8 and 2:256; Medina cooperation; Mauritius Constitution section 11; France's distinct 2004 school-symbol and 2010 face-covering laws. Compare both countries on the same issues.

For “best”: interfaith partnerships can build trust, reduce isolation and address shared poverty/environment concerns. They exemplify civic responsibility without requiring doctrinal agreement.

Alternative: cooperation cannot by itself remove discriminatory law, fund every mosque or replace legal advocacy, political participation and good religious education. A group may lack a willing partner. Minority challenges also include internal resources and differing individual needs.

Evaluation: define “best” by protection of rights and practical benefit. In one setting dialogue may solve misunderstandings; in another a legal route may be necessary alongside dialogue.

Conclusion: assess cooperation as an important strategy, but explain whether and when institutional/legal action must take priority. Do not assert that France bans all Islam or that Mauritius guarantees a difficulty-free life.

Essay 3: obedience and accountability

AO1 evidence: Qur'an 4:59, 4:58, 4:135, 42:38; Bukhari 7257; differing caliphal selection processes; Abduh's institutional reform/Iqbal's active renewal; recent leader evidence where useful.

For accountability: trust is conditional on justice; criticism restrains corruption and protects vulnerable groups. Claiming piety does not excuse oppression.

For obedience/stability: legitimate authority coordinates welfare and security; disorder can undermine the very rights accountability should protect. Citizens have duties as well as claims.

Evaluation: reject the false dichotomy between limitless obedience and violence. Courts, honest advice, consultation, elections and peaceful civic participation can reconcile order with scrutiny. Distinguish lawful authority from a command to wrongdoing.

Conclusion: determine whether one duty sets moral limits on the other, rather than merely declaring them equal. Give a criterion for justified criticism and cooperation.

6. Worked response — Paper 3 Q2(a)

Illustrative AO1 response; read against the source and question, not as a script to reproduce everywhere.

Source B shows a scholar refusing to accept a theory simply because an earlier writer was authoritative. The comparison of a theory with observed light paths illustrates a method in which an explanation must fit evidence. This matters because translation and preservation of older knowledge could become a starting point for criticism, rather than the end of enquiry.

Ibn al-Haytham supplies a named example. In the Book of Optics he explained vision through light entering the eye from objects, rather than rays issuing from the eye. This distinguished his account from an important inherited theory of vision. His work joined mathematical reasoning to experiment: mathematics could clarify the path of light, while observation tested whether a proposed account was compatible with what actually happened.

The source's small opening and darkened space are relevant because they restrict the available light paths, making their effects easier to observe. Recording such observations allows an account to be examined rather than relying only on personal assertion. The significance is therefore not merely that a medieval scholar owned an instrument, but that he used an arranged observation to assess an explanation.

These achievements belong to the wider Islamic intellectual world studied under the Abbasid-era topic. Ibn al-Haytham worked in Fatimid Egypt, so it would be misleading to make him an employee of a Baghdad Abbasid caliph. Intellectual exchange and the movement of texts were wider than one political court. His combination of inherited learning, criticism and evidential reasoning shows why scientific achievement cannot be reduced to copying earlier authorities.

Why this response is useful

It repeatedly connects source detail to a method and then to a named achievement. It avoids a biography dump, a false patronage claim and the unsupported superlative “first scientist”. It could be strengthened further with additional accurately learnt detail, but marks depend on overall quality, not hitting a memorised number of sentences.

7. Worked response — Paper 3 Q2(b)

Openness was important to Abbasid learning because it enlarged the material that scholars could study, but calling it the main reason requires comparing it with the resources and methods that turned inherited knowledge into an intellectual achievement. Success should include both preservation of earlier work and the development of better explanations.

The strongest argument for openness is that useful knowledge was not confined to one linguistic or religious community. Greek material, often transmitted through Syriac, and Persian and Indian traditions contributed to Arabic learning. The work of a Christian translator such as Hunayn ibn Ishaq demonstrates that exchange could draw on expertise across faith boundaries. Without such access, scholars would have had a narrower base from which to work. In that sense openness was foundational rather than an optional decoration.

However, access does not explain why texts could be translated, copied and taught on a large scale. Patronage, libraries, book production and networks of scholars supplied time and material support. Baghdad's political and commercial importance helped sustain intellectual activity. If openness existed without resources, its effects might have been much

smaller. Thus the strongest economic and institutional explanation does not deny openness but shows why it became productive.

A further limitation is that translation is not identical to scientific advance. Ibn al-Haytham's optical work illustrates the importance of examining inherited explanations through mathematical reasoning and observation. His particular Fatimid Egyptian setting also reminds us that the intellectual world was not confined to the Abbasid court. The success of learning depended on scholars who could question and develop what they received. An open library with no critical enquiry might preserve errors as efficiently as truths.

Nor should openness be romanticised as a permanent feature of every Abbasid policy. The mihna reveals pressure to accept a state-supported theological position. This does not erase patronage of learning, but it weakens the sweeping claim that complete intellectual freedom characterised the whole dynasty. The relationship between government, religion and scholars was more contested.

On balance, openness was an essential enabling condition, particularly for translation and the meeting of traditions. Yet I would not treat it as a sufficient or universally dominant cause. For preservation, institutions and book culture were equally decisive; for original advances, critical methods and individual work were crucial. The strongest conclusion is therefore that openness helped make success possible, while organised support and critical enquiry explain how possibility became lasting achievement. That account recognises its importance without reducing centuries of learning to one policy.

AO2 features to notice

The answer defines success, develops the strongest case for the claim, compares it with two distinct alternatives, adds a historical limitation, and judges relative importance. It does not merely list reasons and end with “all mattered”. Other conclusions can be equally creditable if well supported.

8. Worked response — Paper 4 Essay 2

Cooperation with other faiths can be an effective response to minority challenges, but “best” should mean the approach that most reliably protects religious practice and fair participation in a particular setting. Muslims need not abandon their truth claims to work with neighbours on shared civic needs. Nevertheless, cooperation alone cannot remove every legal or economic barrier.

Islamic teachings provide a strong basis for respectful civic relations. Qur'an 60:8 permits kindness and justice toward those who are not fighting or expelling Muslims, while 5:8 requires justice despite dislike. These principles challenge the assumption that religious difference requires social hostility. The arrangements associated with Medina also demonstrate cooperation without all communities having to become religiously identical. In a minority setting, acting fairly toward others can build the mutual trust on which practical accommodation depends.

Mauritius illustrates why cooperation can be fruitful where a constitutional framework already protects religion. Section 11 protects freedom of conscience and religious manifestation and propagation, subject to its lawful limits. Muslim participation in public life can therefore be argued from citizenship as well as from neighbourly goodwill. Cooperation on charitable or environmental projects can make shared interests visible and correct the stereotype that Muslims are an isolated community. Dialogue may also help people understand the practical significance of fasting, prayer and festivals.

However, constitutional protection should not be mistaken for proof that every workplace or school arrangement is effortless. A practical scheduling dispute may require an employer's policy or access to an appropriate remedy, not simply an interfaith event. Cooperation is strongest here when it supports implementation of rights rather than making rights depend entirely on whether a neighbour likes a particular religious practice. Otherwise a vulnerable person could be expected to earn basic fairness through public popularity.

France raises a different set of institutional questions. The 2004 restrictions concern conspicuous religious symbols for pupils in state primary and secondary schools. They should not be confused with the separate 2010 law concerning concealment of the face in public space. This distinction matters: claiming that France bans every hijab everywhere would misidentify the challenge and make the proposed response unreliable. Supporters of school neutrality argue that shared rules protect pupils and civic cohesion; critics argue that such restrictions can burden religious expression and educational choice, especially for visibly Muslim girls.

Interfaith dialogue may reduce prejudice and give critics of restrictions allies beyond their own community. It can also show that freedom of conscience is not only a Muslim concern. Yet dialogue cannot by itself change a national legal rule. Legal argument, political participation and careful public advocacy may be needed. Cooperation could assist those approaches, but replacing them with a vague appeal to harmony would leave the institutional issue untouched. The best strategy must address the actual source of the difficulty.

There are also challenges that cooperation does not directly solve, such as a community's limited resources for religious education, or disagreement about how to explain Islam responsibly. Internal education and ethical da'wah remain relevant. Qur'an 16:125 supports wise invitation; that can include accurate explanation and personal example, not only public debate. Cooperation should not require concealing all beliefs, and charity should not be conditional on conversion. Genuine partnership respects the other participant's freedom as well as one's own.

The comparison therefore supports a qualified judgement. In Mauritius, cooperation may be especially valuable for translating constitutional coexistence into everyday relationships. In France, it can challenge prejudice and widen support, but legal and institutional engagement may be more directly necessary in a dispute about a formal restriction. In neither case does minority status make withdrawal from civic life the only faithful option.

Overall, cooperation is one of the best general attitudes and a powerful practical method, but it is not a complete response on its own. It works best alongside enforceable rights, informed religious education and lawful participation. The strongest alternative conclusion—that legal protection should take priority—is persuasive when rights are directly restricted; however, law without social trust may still leave daily hostility. A combined strategy is justified not because compromise is automatically correct, but because minority challenges arise from both institutions and relationships.

AO1/AO2 features to notice

AO1 supplies specific teachings, two countries and accurately distinguished laws. AO2 weighs dialogue against institutional remedies, develops both legal and social criteria and explains why different contexts alter the judgement. No invented survey or sweeping country stereotype is required.

9. Worked evaluative paragraph — Paper 4 Essay 1

Razia's rule in Delhi from 1236 to 1240 challenges the absolute historical claim that a Muslim woman could never exercise sovereign authority. Nevertheless, a historical example does not by itself settle the interpretation of the report cited by jurists restricting female rule. The stronger argument supporting women's eligibility must therefore explain why the report should be applied contextually or differently to different modern offices, and connect that interpretation with justice and competence. Conversely, Razia's eventual fall cannot demonstrate female incapacity, because male rulers also faced elite opposition and succession conflict. Her case is strongest as evidence of possibility and institutional resistance, not as a shortcut proving every legal or political conclusion.

Upgrade a weak paragraph

Weak: “Islam respects women. Bhutto was prime minister. Therefore women can do anything and everyone agrees.”

Better: specify the disputed office, develop a relevant teaching, explain the example, acknowledge a serious interpretation against your view and show why your criterion outweighs it. Replace universal slogans with defensible claims.

10. Additional practice angles — not additional predictions

Use these for five-minute plans and short paragraphs rather than memorising another complete essay.

Paper 3

1. How does a minaret communicate practical and religious purposes?
2. Were Abbasid religious policies more influential than their scientific legacy?
3. Can Greek methods be used without adopting every Greek conclusion?
4. What can gardens communicate about Paradise, and what can they not communicate?
5. Does calligraphy teach belief more precisely than geometry?
6. How should a Muslim community balance heritage preservation and urgent welfare needs?
7. Compare one Umayyad and one Abbasid policy against the same Qur'anic criterion.
8. Evaluate the continuing usefulness of Muslim Spain as an interfaith example.

Paper 4

1. Is spiritual equality the same as identical legal roles?
2. Is Aisha's example most relevant through scholarship or public participation?
3. Compare Razia's route to power with Noor Jahan's.

4. Does minority status necessarily restrict da'wah?
5. Is civic equality compatible with maintaining exclusive religious truth claims?
6. Do modern elections fulfil shura, or only provide one possible mechanism?
7. Is a leader's religious identity sufficient evidence of trustworthiness?
8. Compare Abduh's institutional reform with Iqbal's intellectual renewal.

11. Self-assessment sheet

For each attempt record:

- Date, paper/question, time spent and case studies used.
- AO1 provisional mark /10 and one sentence explaining the descriptor fit.
- AO2 provisional mark /15 and one sentence explaining how alternatives were weighed.
- One inaccurate/unsupported claim to correct from a reliable source.
- One paragraph rewritten to address the exact question more directly.
- One missing syllabus connection to revise next.

Peer review: underline evidence, circle the reasoning connecting it to the question, and box the final judgement. If there is much evidence but little reasoning, adding another biography is not the solution.

12. Flexible seven-session revision plan

Adjust session length to the actual time remaining; do not assume these are seven calendar days before your exam. Confirm your friends' component dates with their centre.

1. Read the syllabus map, confirm optional cases; do a short AO1 diagnostic and one P4 essay plan.

2. Umayyad/Abbasid leadership and policies; source drill using two ORIGINAL figures; dynastic comparison.
3. Scientist/methods and two works; write one P3(a) and one P3(b), then mark separately.
4. Two mosques, gardens, calligraphy and stewardship; timed Section B question.
5. Women: early/historical/recent cases, rights and public roles; timed P4 women/crossover essay.
6. Pluralism and leadership: two countries, Spain, caliphs, reformers and recent leader; two contrasting plans.
7. Sit both practice papers in separate 90-minute blocks if time permits; correct errors, then revise only the weakest links. If time is short, do one full paper and plan the other without sacrificing sleep.

Final check: no entire syllabus section omitted; names/dates/works accurate; quotations understood; source figures actually used; conclusions answer the precise qualifier (“main”, “only”, “best”, “more”, “sufficient”).